

my game further. No doubt, sports hostels have played a huge role in shaping my journey.

How was it to change position from a centre half?

As a center half, my primary responsibility was distributing balls. However, Siva sir believed in my goal-scoring potential, prompting me to focus on drills that enhanced my shooting skills.

From your first coach, Raja, to the current Indian men's team coach, Craig Fulton, how have they groomed your game and style?

Each coach has taught me something important for a lifetime. I learnt a lot from everyone. Being in the same Indian team as B.J. Kariappa sir was an enlightening affair, while Sardar Singh shared his own experience while being a coach.

As for the senior team coaches, Fulton and Graham Reid, their approaches are different. When I was not selected for the junior World Cup, Reid advised me to enhance my speed and footwork. While under Fulton's guidance, I was provided with an opportunity to display my skills in the Pro League.

Reid taught me the importance of speed as he relies more on counter-attacks while Fulton insisted on building the game within the established structure. Both have taught me to be quicker and the need to work on movements.

Why didn't you get to play more in juniors?

That was due to the lockdown. When I got a chance in the men's Asia Cup, I proved my worth by scoring a goal against Pakistan. Overall, I did well.

How was the atmosphere in that game against Pakistan in the Dhaka Asia Cup?

When we face Pakistan, the crowd is always charged-up. It was no different in Dhaka. My confidence grew sky-high after my first goal in that match. Subsequently, I performed well in the following games. Reid was very helpful as he



analysed my game after every match and told me to maintain consistency at all costs. The Asia Cup memories were very sweet, with the seniors sharing their experiences and making me feel like I belong.

How have the senior players guided you?

Harmanpreet, who has been my idol ever since I started playing hockey, gave me instructions on how to receive the ball better. Mandeep advised me on not only how to stand while receiving the ball, but also how to cut and pass. Everyone has been so friendly that I picked up Hindi

quite easily.

You were very impressive in the ACT. How was your experience in the tournament?

It was the first time that I was playing for the Indian team in front of a home crowd, which was really great. Also, playing in front of my parents was special indeed. The fans supported me too. There was so much energy in every match.

How was it training with your State mates for the Goa National Games?

I mingled with them well. It is not